

“We need to tell our stories to
each other, even when it hurts.”



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Adri M.

She came down from the mountains.

VOL. 1, THE WITNESS

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She came down

from the mountains

VOL 1 // THE WITNESS

Adri M.

for course GRSJ515 // Winter 2026

SHE CAME DOWN FROM THE MOUNTAINS

VOL. 1, THE WITNESS

This zine traces five generations of women from the stolen **Huetar** land of **Itskazú** and **Acerri** to **Turtle Island**. It is an archive in three voices and a record of resilience against settler-colonial violence.

*To **Maruca** and **Anita**, for the resilience.
To **Tacha** and **Lore**, also for the stories.
To **Zoe**, for the future.
And to all the women before them.*

Available online:



Adri M.
GRSJ515, Winter 2026
polivoxia.ca

Colophon (v. 1.0.1). 8.5 × 13.13 in saddle-stitched booklet, printed half-size. Set in **Atkinson Hyperlegible**, **Courier Prime**, and **Fraunces**. Cover background: a grainy-photocopy hillshade of the **Aserri** topography, land of **Chief Acerri**. All image effects done with custom-made software. Typeset in Typst. Imposed with Plica.

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What stories are still moving?

What mountains did your people come down from?

What names has your archive risked of losing?

Who came before you?

FIVE GENERATIONS

THE WOMEN OF THIS ARCHIVE

I. Maruca

Born some time in the 1910s. She came down from the land of Chief Acserrí. They called her María Eugenia, but she never told her name. She worked as an indentured maid until she died after giving birth to Anita.

II. Anita

Born 1931 in the Zúñiga Gutiérrez house, indentured in her own home. She started slipping back to the mountains at ten. She met Carlos in the park at fourteen, married him at sixteen, and was expelled then from the family. She never returned.

III. Lorena

Born in 1956. She was Anita's eldest daughter. She took the bus from Itskazú to the capital to visit who she thought was her uncle. On one of those trips she met Héctor. They fell wildly in love.

IV. Natacha

Born in 1979. She crossed from Huetar land to Turtle Island and made a new life there.

V. Zoe

Born in 2016. The youngest of the line and the future of it. A word that means life.

YOUR WITNESS

FOR YOUR OWN STORIES,
NAMES, AND PLACES.

We need to tell our stories to each other, even when it hurts.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dashed lines.

Traditions of storytelling are integrally linked to gatherings of commemoration, protest, and resistance.

Amahl Bishara,
"Speaking Across Generations and Geographies
of the Ongoing Nakba at Seventy-six"

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She came down from the mountains.

Nobody was sure why
or how, but one day
she descended
from the land
of **Chief Acserrí**
to the Valley.

Maruca, they called her,
though they weren't sure
if that was her real name.

Some called her **María Eugenia**.
If she had another name, she never told.

Her skin was brown. Her hair was dark,
long and silky, and she kept it
neatly tied back.

Everyone looked at her
when she came in.

She was a **big presence**
wherever she was.

It was the 1920s in so-called Costa Rica's **Itskazú**: a land stolen by the **Spanish** centuries ago, whose **Indigenous** people they murdered, enslaved, and displaced, relegated to hard-to-reach areas like jungles or the top of the **mountains**.

Nobody knows the names of those people either. They were called **Huetares** by the **settlers**, and that's how they are remembered now.

The road to peace envisages a straight line from violence to freedom, yet it has historically proven to be a much more complicated geometry.”

Ghanayem, E. *Traveling Indigently*.
Native American and Indigenous Studies.

We need to tell our stories to each other, even when it hurts. We need to say the names of our martyrs and prisoners, and to say place names too, even when those names might seem insignificant.”

Bishara, A. *Speaking Across Generations*.
Native American and Indigenous Studies.

The testimonies of women are acts of resistance that challenge the erasure of their existence and assert their right to life and to land.”

Ihmoud, S. *Countering Reproductive Genocide*.
Native American and Indigenous Studies.

EPILOGUE • WITNESS

Natacha is my partner and the mother of my daughter **Zoe**, who shares the legacy of all the women who came before her.

I tell these stories as a witness. In sharing these lives I try to honour the legacy of all these women who survived against all odds; who never stopped resisting and gave all they had.

I tell these stories to keep them alive and make them known. They are still being written and told, they are still moving.

**They are not the past;
they are our present **resistance**.**

The notion of the Indigenous as static serves all settler colonial states in their attempts to relegate Indigenous people to the past.“

Kauanui, J. K. *Enduring Palestine.*
Native American and Indigenous Studies.

THE ZÚÑIGA GUTIÉRREZ HOUSE

Maruca, seeking a way to sustain her life, found the **Zúñiga Gutiérrez** house. They were **criollos**, direct descendants of those **Spanish conquistadores** and **settlers**. “**People of God**”, “**good Christians**”, they let her stay and work as a maid.

PEOPLE IN THE HOUSE

- **El Señor**
- **La Señora**
- **Two daughters**
- **Five sons**
- **The gardener**
- **The maid**

It was a contract without writing, paper or ink. It was **indentured servitude** after all. The terms were never written down. They never had to be.

The gardener called himself by the Spanish name **Juvenal**, but he too came from the mountains; his original name also lost.

Juvenal and **Maruca** fell in love.

And in 1931, **Anita** was born.

Born from the **mountain people** who lost their names, language, and culture, yet **endured**.

Even when humanity has failed,
we continue to birth our people;“

Amahl Bishara,
“Speaking Across Generations and Geographies
of the Ongoing Nakba at Seventy-six”

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Zoe shares the legacy of all the women who came before her. Like **Maruca**, **Anita**, **Lorena** and **Natacha**, she also came down from the mountains of the land of **Chief Acserri**, on the shoulders of her ancestors.



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And here, in this also stolen land, **Natacha**'s daughter was born. **Zoe**. A word that means life.

NATACHA

IN 100 WORDS

Electricity, two lightning bolts circling a gentle shadow you can get lost in. Features so imprinted in your mind that will never be forgotten.

An old, heavy, loud love. The one given not by innocence but by a life shared in happiness, pain, struggle and trust.

A space both of respite and of challenge. Where comfort can be found but complacency is not welcome.

The scent of cinnamon, turmeric, clove and coffee frame dark and brown hues, outlined by the marks of a life lived to its fullest.

Passion; an eternal wild fire burning inside, handed down for generations.

ZOE

IN 100 WORDS

A warm ray of sunshine turned human. Unbridled love as the expression of a soul full of trust, that hasn't yet known fear.

Passion, surface manifestation of true emotions that yet go deep and wide. Clear words that know how to express thoughts.

Peace, the kind only found on those unmarred by the inexorable harshness of life.

Serenity, the absolute surrender allowed to those who dream truly.

Whiffs of metaphorical yet ever-present flowers. A bouquet of daisies and lavenders with hints of almond and strawberries.

Softness, happiness, sweetness, but an eternal wild fire burning inside, handed down for generations.

ITSKAZÚ · HUETAR · ACSERRÍ · MONTAÑAS

SHECAMEDOWNFROMTHEMOUNTAINSNOBODYWASSUREWHYORHOWBUTONEDAYSHEDESCENDEDFROMTHELANDOFCHIE
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NFROMTHEMOUNTAINPEOPLEWHOLOSTT
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SFAILEDMECONTINUETOIRTHOURPEO
MESHEESCAPEDESHWASYEARSOLDMEGU
EXPLORARMESENTIALIBRESHECONTINU
HENEVERSHOULDHERMOTHERCAMEDOWN
TAINSANITALIKEDTOESCAPEBACKTOTHEM
HERANAWAYWITHCARLOSANDGOTMARRIEDSH
IGAGUTIERREZLASTNAMESANDBECAMEANIT
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SEMARIAEUGENIAFERNANDOMARTIN THEY
ERSTOPOVERTYLORENATOOKTHEBUSFROMI
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LLOSDIRECTDESC ENDANTS OFTHO SEPANISHCONQUIS TADORESPPEOPLEOF
ODCHRISTIANSTHEY LETHERS TAYA NDWORKASAMADJUV ENALANDMARUCAFELLINLO
DINANITA WASBORNB ORNFROM THEM OUNTAINPEOPLEWH OLOSTTHEIRNAMESLANGUAGE
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OE SCAPEB ACKTOTH E MWHE NSHEWA SSSH
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NA NJOSEMARIAEUGENIAFERNANDOMARTIN THEYALSOLOSTINENOTHERSTOPOVERTYLORENATOOKTHEBUSFROMITS

RESISTANCE · RESILIENCE · WILD FIRE · LIFE

A RECORD OF GOOD WORKS

Things changed abruptly when **Anita** was only one month old and **Maruca** fell ill.

The settler Christian family she worked for did not give her a break after the birth. She had to keep **doing her job**: going to the river to wash the clothes of ten people, among other tasks.

They said she got **espasmos** (spasms), but nobody really knows why she died.

The settler **Zuñaiga Gutiérrez** family, **good Christians** as they were, took in baby **Anita**. They took care of her, as long as she knew her place.

They gave her their last names. She became **Anita Zuñaiga Gutiérrez** but she had to work for them as hard as her mother. She was now an investment.

They fed her one cup of coffee and one piece of bread for breakfast; whatever was left for dinner. The family always called it **Christian CHARITY**.

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Los hijos de Anita.



Lorena frente a su casa, con gente del barrio.

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Time moved on.

Years later, **Hernán**, who **Anita** still thought was her brother, got into trouble and ended up in **prison**.

Anita's health was too weak to visit, so she sent her eldest daughter, **Lorena**.

Every time, **Lorena** took the bus from Itskazú to the capital and visited who she thought was her uncle, not knowing it was her **grandfather**.

It was on one of those bus trips that she met **Héctor**.

Lorena and Héctor fell **wildly in love**.

They had a daughter:

NATACHA

Unexpected destiny brought **Natacha** to **Turtle Island**, where she became an uninvited guest. The daughter of displaced people living amongst others sharing a similar oppression. **Indigeneity from South to North**.

Years later, when old-age **Anita** remembered those years, she called it

TORTURE



Years passed and **Anita** grew up thinking she was a **zūñiga Gutiérrez** child.

Nobody ever told her
about **Maruca**,
her past,
her relationship
with **Juvenal**.

Reproducing the eliminatory violence
of settler colonialism.

She cooked.
She made everyone's beds.
She worked as an indentured
maid at her own house.

It was only when she was older that she started
questioning things, noticing how her skin was **darker** than
her sisters' and brothers'.

It was then that she also began to

escape
back
to
the
mountains.

6

reproductive genocide

Anita renounced everything and moved in with Carlos. He used to work the banana plantations on the Caribbean coast, but was now a baker.

Together they built a house and had **nine** children:

Carlos Miguel
Luis Alberto
Ana Lorena
Guillermo Martín
Luis Ángel
María de los Ángeles
Hernán José
María Eugenia
Fernando Martín

They also lost **nine** others to poverty. Poverty that also affected her health, after years of enduring.

A dark and brutal example of the violence of European modernity on the land and on our bodies.“

Barakat, R. *In Search of Words:
A Temporary Title for Horror.*
Native American and Indigenous Studies.

Her mother came down from the mountains.
Anita liked to escape back to them.

The first time she escaped, she was **10 years old**.

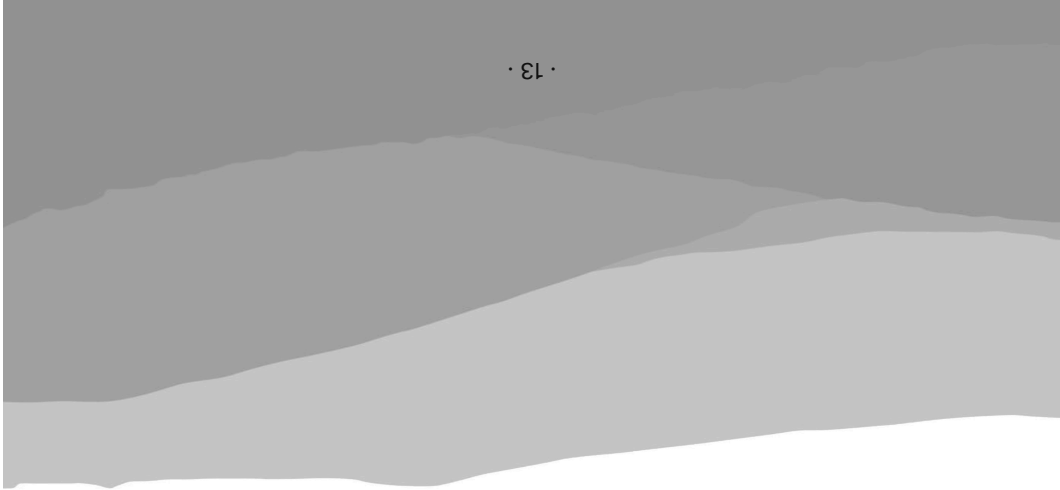
Me gustaba zafarme y explorar. Me sentía libre.

- Anita

(I liked to break out and explore. I felt free.)

When she came back, she was punished. They **locked** her in and **denied** her food. Yet, she **continued to escape**.

Her brother **Hernán**, twenty years older, sneaked her food when she was starved. He had always been kind. After primary school, he paid for her studies as a **seamstress**. Little by little, she was able to learn a craft.



• 13 •

darker

Itskazú

me sentia libre

than her sisters'

and brothers'

wild fire

Me gustaba zafarme

she came down from the mountains

darker

Acserri

16 years old • never to return again

• 18 •

EXPULSED

the way she was known until the day she died.

When she came back to the house and told them what had happened, they first tried to convince her, offering her money, inheritance. When she didn't relinquish, they threatened her, disavowed her, and finally came clear: she was adopted anyway.

ANITA MORA

When she was 16, she ran away with **Carlos** and got married. She shed the **Zúñiga Gutiérrez** last names and became



Anita y Carlos · bailando

Her family was opposed. Hernán didn't like Carlos, and she was supposed to marry someone else as part of the Christian family business. She was already sold.

So Anita escaped

**one
last
time.**

bastard daughter

Hernán el criollo

indentured servitude

the secret

Christian charity

good Christians

the maid

settler colonialism

Hernán el criollo

sold

When Anita was 14 years old, she was allowed to go to the park for one hour with her sisters. That was the social space of the moment: girls walked around the park in one direction, while boys walked in the opposite one. It was there where she met Carlos Mora.

girls →	→ walk this way →
around →	→ around
again →	→ again
again →	→ again
again →	→ again
→ Carlos Mora	

They fell in love.

Old-age Anita, decades later, reflected how she came to realize Hernán was not her brother but her real father.

She remembered all his attentions and pondered how she was not born from Maruca and Juvenal the gardener, but from Hernán el criollo, son of Spanish settlers. All kept a secret, this is what made the Zúñiga Gutiérrez take her in, since she was their bastard daughter. It all helps explain all the duresses she had to go through.